Following her trip, Davis stayed in West Germany for another year, through the spring of 1967. She left to finish her graduate work in California, citing her desire to return to the front lines of the movement in the United States and to study with her Brandeis mentor Marcuse, who had relocated to the University of California at San Diego. Soon after returning to the United States, Davis was catapulted into national headlines by her intertwined academic work and activism. Her public travails included a high-profile removal from her position as a philosophy lecturer at the University of California, Los Angeles (UCLA), in 1969–70 because of her membership in the Communist Party. Later, she spent three months on the FBI's Top Ten Most Wanted list as a fugitive, stemming from a contrived charge of aiding the kidnapping and murder of a judge in California in 1970. After she was arrested, she was detained for eighteen months in New York and California prisons, during which a widespread international solidarity movement emerged across dozens of countries, including West and East Germany, heeding the call to "Free Angela and all political prisoners." She was eventually acquitted after a widely publicized trial in 1972 in which Davis faced the death penalty.

During the trial, as sensationalizing details of her life story swirled through the national and international media reports, Davis and her legal defense committee circulated their own biographical documents and pamphlets, to support their grassroots efforts for a fair trial. They also advanced their defense of Davis by mounting campaigns for other political prisoners. The documents presented by her defense team routinely mentioned her time as a graduate student in West Germany, which directly preceded her return to the United States. They presented these details of her specialized training in academia, in part, to accentuate the international reach of her activism. Given her academic and personal connections to West Germany, solidarity campaigns for Davis also sprouted up across the country, including in Frankfurt and West Berlin. As a member of the Communist Party, she also shared a special relationship with the people and government of East Germany; before and during her trial German Democratic Republic (GDR) officials mounted sweeping solidarity campaigns in her defense, expressed in both state-run and grassroots efforts. Following the trial and her eventual acquittal, Davis left the United States on an international tour to places that had been integral to her solidarity movement for freedom, including socialist East Berlin.